



Sorted Once, Seated All Term

A Comparison of Week-One Diagnostic Table-Colour Groups Against Week-Nine Tutorial Performance

Lindiwe Achterberg · Anouk Mensah — School of Emergent Priorities

The problem

First-year tutorial rooms sort students into colour-coded table groups from a single week-one diagnostic quiz. Despite growing interest in responsive small-group teaching, little is known about whether that first placement still describes anyone by the time assessment begins.

Research questions

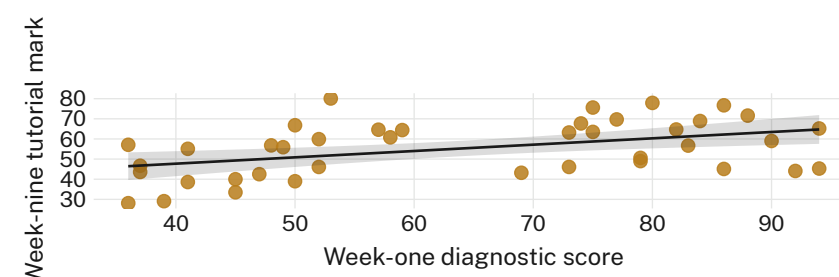
- Does week-one table colour predict week-nine tutorial performance?
- How often does a student's marked ability diverge from their assigned colour?
- Do tutors reassign colours as divergence accumulates?

Study design

- 214 first-year students · 3 table colours (gold, ink, grey-tint) · 9 weekly tutorial marks · one teaching period
- Week-one diagnostic score fixed table placement; week-nine mark set from a blinded tutor rubric
- Reassignment tracked as a binary flag per student per week; no manual override recorded outside the flag

What we found

Week-one colour explains a shrinking share of week-nine performance (partial R^2 falling from 0.41 to 0.09 across the term); most students who crossed a full grade band were never reassigned.



Week-nine marks correlate only weakly with the week-one score that fixed each student's colour ($r = 0.24$, $n = 214$).

Implications

Table colour persists as shorthand long after it stops describing performance; reassignment is procedurally possible but practically rare. Next: trial a mid-term recolour keyed to the same rubric.

Selected references

1. Slavin, R. E. (1990). Achievement effects of ability grouping in secondary schools: A best-evidence synthesis. *Review of Educational Research*, 60(3), 471–499. doi:10.3102/00346543060003471
2. Francis, B., Archer, L., Hodgen, J., Pepper, D., Taylor, B., & Travers, M.-C. (2017). Attainment grouping as self-fulfilling prophesy? A mixed methods exploration of self confidence and set level among Year 7 students. *International Journal of Educational Research*, 86, 96–108. doi:10.1016/j.ijer.2017.09.001
3. Francis, B., Craig, N., Hodgen, J., Taylor, B., Tereshchenko, A., Connolly, P., & Archer, L. (2020). The impact of tracking by attainment on pupil self-confidence over time: demonstrating the accumulative impact of self-fulfilling prophecy. *British Journal of Sociology of Education*, 41(5), 626–642. doi:10.1080/01425692.2020.1763162
4. Hallinan, M. T. (1996). Track mobility in secondary school. *Social Forces*, 74(3), 983–1002. doi:10.1093/sf/74.3.983
5. Lindqvist, K., Vasseur, I., & Okafor, D. (2026). New Scorecard, Same Waitlist: Auditing a Priority-Tier Overhaul of Campus Parking-Permit Allocation Under a Cap Frozen Against Rising Enrolment. School of Emergent Priorities, Slop University. doi:10.5555/slop.6apmck

Rubric approval 2026/T1-19; de-identified marks only.

Office of Research Outputs · slop.university



“The gold table stayed gold.”

71% of students who crossed a full grade band kept their week-one colour through week nine.